

Example Performance Review Conversation Plan

A filled-in sample from the Review Conversation Planner

This is an example. The employee and details are fictional. Use it to see the kind of detail that makes a plan useful, then write your own answers in the planner.

Section 1: Prepare the employee

Purpose, agenda, and outcomes

What will you say to explain the purpose of the review and what you'll discuss?

This review is a chance for us to look back at the past year together, talk through what went well and what was harder, and agree on priorities for next year. We'll start with your self-evaluation, then I'll share my observations, and we'll finish by setting goals.

What will you say to explain what you want to accomplish during the review?

By the end, I want us both to have a shared view of your performance, two or three clear goals for next year, and a sense of the support you need from me to reach them.

Who you'll talk to and what sources you'll review

Who will you speak with, and what information will you use to review the employee's performance?

I'll speak with the two project leads you worked with most this year. I'll also use your quarterly goal tracker, ticket resolution data, and the customer survey results for your accounts.

Self-evaluation

Why is self-evaluation important?

Your perspective matters as much as mine, and it helps me see things I might have missed. It also makes the review a two-way conversation instead of a one-sided assessment.

What questions will you ask the employee to think about before the review?

What are you most proud of this year? Where did you get stuck? What would help you do your best work next year?

Section 2: Prepare yourself

Employee data and examples

What measurable performance data have you gathered about the employee's performance?

Resolved 94% of tickets within the service-level target (team goal 90%). Customer satisfaction averaged 4.6 out of 5. Two of four quarterly project milestones were delivered late.

What specific examples demonstrate where the employee was effective or struggled to achieve their goals?

Effective: led the onboarding redesign that cut new-client setup time by a week. Struggled: the Q3 reporting migration slipped three weeks because dependencies weren't flagged early.

What feedback have coworkers, stakeholders, or customers shared about the employee during the performance period?

A client wrote that their questions were always answered clearly and quickly. A project stakeholder praised the onboarding redesign. A coworker asked for an earlier heads-up when timelines are at risk.

Preparing your message

Which key responsibilities will you focus on during the review?

Client support quality, project delivery, and cross-team communication.

What are the employee's top two or three strengths that will help them succeed in the future?

Clear communicator with clients; strong problem-solver; takes ownership of process improvements.

What are the top two or three areas where the employee should grow or improve?

Flagging risks earlier; breaking large projects into milestones; delegating routine work.

What are the two or three key areas you want the employee to focus on in the next performance period?

Delivering quarterly milestones on time; weekly status updates on active projects; mentoring a newer team member.

Prepare and Plan for Reactions

What reactions might come up, and how will you respond?

They may ask about a raise or promotion. I'll acknowledge the question, explain that compensation follows a separate process and timeline, and connect today's goals to future growth.

They may hesitate to talk about their performance. I'll ask open, low-pressure questions, allow silence, and start with one positive example to set a comfortable tone.

If they get defensive or shift blame, I'll stay calm, stick to specific facts, acknowledge their view, and ask what they could do differently next time.